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"*War is the continuation of politics by other means"* stated Carl von Clausewitz famously. Nowadays, this insight extends beyond the battlefield. From the economic sanctions on Russia to the technology competition between the United States and China, as well as the rapid expansion of artificial intelligence is increasingly exercised through infrastructures that control the flow of information and money instead of through straightforward military actions. Traditionally, empires have relied on two main foundations: systems for communication and structures for finance. Trade paths, telegraph lines, undersea cables, and online platforms have allowed for organization across distances, while financial systems, stock markets, and world currencies have helped in the abstraction and accumulation of capital. In today's world, these relationships have not vanished; they have only become stronger. Communication is now fast, digital, and worldwide, while financial activities have become more speculative due to the growth of credit and reliance on technology. This leads to an important question: How do communication infrastructures and financial systems interact to produce and reproduce hegemonic power, and how does this interaction explain the rise, stability, and decline of empires from the Genoese to the digital age? In what ways do contemporary developments—such as submarine cables, AI bubbles, and platform capitalism—reflect or challenge historical patterns of imperial power? This essay contends that empires do more than just depend on communication networks and financial structures; their authority arises from the ongoing interaction between the two. Communication networks allow for organization across distances, financial systems enable value abstraction, and together they create structural dependencies that uphold leading power. From Genoa through to the United States, the longevity of empires has relied on their skill in harmonizing these aspects, with crises happening when that harmony fails. To illustrate this point, the essay will begin by establishing a theoretical approach based on significant contributions in political economics and media studies. It then analyzes past dominant structures to demonstrate how communication and capital have fused to generate influence. The focus then shifts to modern digital systems, arguing that they amplify rather than change these patterns. Lastly, the essay looks into current crises as crucial moments of misalignment, providing insights into potential paths for the global order.

I. Theoretical Foundations: Communication, Capital, and Infrastructural Power

Looking at empires requires understanding communication systems and financial structures not as neutral tools, but as mechanisms of power and control across spatial scales and historical timeframes and also, concentrating in urban knots. Harold Innis argues that all media carry an inherent "bias" that shapes political organization. Media oriented toward time tend to produce centralized and stable systems, while media oriented toward space enable territorial expansion. From this perspective, communication infrastructures such as print, telegraph networks, and today's internet do not merely transmit information; they structure how power is distributed across space and time.Building on this, Giovanni Arrighi shows that global hegemony emerges through recurring cycles linking finance and communication. From Genoa to nowadays the United States or China, each dominant power combines financial innovation with key communication infrastructures: trade routes, print capitalism, telegraph systems, and the internet. These cycles are periodically disrupted by crises that signal either a transition or the decline of hegemonic power. These two perspectives converge to the concept of infrastructural power: systems such as cables, digital platforms, and financial networks generate relations of dependency and control. Contemporary digital capitalism illustrates this clearly, as platforms extract value from user data while also shaping access to information. Similarly, Saskia

Sassen's work on global cities highlights how financial and communication infrastructures concentrate power in key urban nodes such as New York, London, and Shanghai.

Taken together, hegemonic power emerges not from any single domain, but from the continuous alignment between communication infrastructures, financial systems, and the spatial nodes that concentrate and stabilize their interaction.What appears historically as imperial power can be understood as the recurring alignment between infrastructures that organize communication, systems that abstract and circulate value, and spatial nodes where these processes are concentrated. Having established the theoretical foundations, we now turn to historical examples to illustrate how empires have concretely articulated communication and capital to build power. From Genoa to the United States, each hegemonic cycle (Arrighi, 1994) was underpinned by specific infrastructures—whether trade routes, stock exchanges, or telegraph cables. Can we not understand historical hegemonies, as successive instantiations of a single structural logic, each defined by a specific alignment of interests, between the organization of communication and the abstraction of capital. Can we say that Imperial powers, in order to obtain hegemonic power, used infrastructures to evolve ?

II. Historical Mechanisms: The Evolution of Hegemonic Alignment

Each historical configuration represents a different way of resolving the tension between the circulation of information and the abstraction of capital, with crises emerging when this balance becomes unstable. In this part of the essay, we will argue that historical continuities are evident in the study of empires, thanks to infrastructural and a favorable financial system. Infrastructures, therefore, clearly shaped political power in the rise of the empires.
Across history, hegemonic power does not emerge from territorial control alone, but from the alignment between communication infrastructures and the financial system. In the case of Genoa in the modern times, the weakening of direct commercial dominance following its rivalry with Venice did not eliminate its influence but transformed its role within the emerging European system (Braudel, 1982). Financial networks increasingly mediated imperial expansion by financing larger overseas projects, particularly Spanish ventures. Capital thus replaced territorial control as the primary vector of influence, enabling coordination across distance without direct sovereignty. The cycle does not stop here. It is further developed in the Dutch cycle, where the emergence of joint-stock companies and early financial markets deepens the integration between capital and information. The expansion of print culture, especially financial news and market reports, enables more synchronized economic coordination. Value creation becomes increasingly dependent on expectations shaped through communication flows, linking financial accumulation to informational infrastructures. The British case marks a decisive intensification of this dynamic. Global telegraph networks and the gold standard establish a tightly integrated system of real-time communication and monetary standardization. Coordination becomes instantaneous across imperial space, while value is stabilized through a unified monetary framework. At this stage, power is exercised less through territorial administration than through the regulation of interconnected flows of information and capital. (Arrighi, 1994)

This configuration reaches a new level of abstraction in the United States, where digital communication networks and global financial systems converge. The internet enables continuous coordination of information flows at planetary scale, while dollar-based financial structures extend monetary abstraction across global markets. However, this increasing integration also generates systemic fragilities, as financial expansion begins to outpace the material and informational infrastructures that sustain it, producing recurrent crises and speculative bubbles.

Across these successive configurations, hegemonic power can be understood as the evolving alignment between communication infrastructures, financial systems, and the structural dependencies they generate. Crises emerge not as external shocks, but as moments in which this alignment breaks down, revealing the internal limits of each hegemonic formation.

However, if historical empires relied on physical infrastructures (trade routes, telegraph cables), contemporary power is increasingly mediated through digital infrastructures. How do these new systems reshape global power?

III. Contemporary Infrastructures: Digital Capitalism and Geopolitical Power : le numérique n'est pas une rupture, mais une intensification

Modern forms of global influence do not signify a break from previous dominant frameworks but rather enhance their foundational principles. The push towards digital communication and finance has strengthened the connections between information systems and capital growth, prolonging historical trends of power into the online world. A key aspect of this shift is what is known as surveillance capitalism. In this setup, value is generated not mainly through making things, but by gathering, analyzing, and selling behavioral data. Digital services like search engines and social media act both as ways to communicate and as tools for predicting and managing behavior. The flow of information is tightly linked to economic exploitation, where data becomes a vital resource for creating value and achieving market power. From this angle, today's digital systems act as power structures that dictate access to information, visibility, and social organization on a worldwide level.
This power dynamic is physically supported by the actual infrastructure of global communication, especially submarine cable networks, which form the unseen foundation of today's digital economy. Though they are not always visible in daily life, these systems carry most of the world's internet traffic and dictate the conditions necessary for digital communication to occur. Control and ownership of these cables are held by a small number of corporations and government entities, leading to imbalances in global connectivity. Like past communication infrastructures used for imperial purposes, these cables do more than convey information; they create global dependencies by influencing the speed, reliability, and order of information exchanges. In this way, submarine cables serve as essential coordination infrastructures, similar to the role of telegraph systems in the imperial age.

The political significance of this infrastructure is growing. The split in global digital spaces is shown by the strategic competition for control and development of alternative cable systems. China's efforts to build its own infrastructures, combined with Western control of current networks, demonstrates how communication pathways are key tools in geopolitical conflicts. Therefore, control over connectivity is not only a technical issue but also a strategic one, influencing how informational power is divided worldwide.

Additionally, financial systems are now closely linked to digital infrastructures. Activities such as algorithmic trading and capital accumulation through platforms operate within the same informational networks that underpin digital communication. This merging creates a scenario where financial complexity and information flow support each other, leading to greater interconnectedness and increased risk.

The stability of this connection is threatened by the emergence of artificial intelligence, which acts as both a cutting-edge technology and a financial asset. The swift influx of funding into AI companies

reflects not just technological ambitions but also speculative behaviors driven by expectations for the future. Like past historical patterns, these trends can lead to financial bubbles where the hopes for rapid growth surpass the infrastructure and production abilities needed to maintain them. In this way, AI serves both as a technological framework and as a financial system based on future expectations. When considered as a whole, these changes indicate that modern digital systems do not significantly change how dominant power works. Instead, they amplify this power by speeding up cooperation across different areas, broadening the concept of capital, and increasing global reliance on infrastructure that is still controlled unevenly. Communication, Capital and Power, therefore mingle in one super-structure.

If contemporary infrastructures—submarine cables, AI, surveillance capitalism—are the new tools of power, then the crises they generate (financial bubbles, geopolitical tensions) may signal transitions in the global order. As Arrighi (1994) demonstrated, such crises are not random; they are structural and often precede the decline of one hegemony and the rise of another.

IV. Crises and Transitions: *Signal Crisis*, *Terminal Crisis*, and the Future of Hegemony

This last part of our analysis will demonstrate that crises do not simply result from external shocks; they emerge when the mechanisms of coordination and abstraction become misaligned—when financial systems expand beyond the infrastructural capacities that sustain them.
The conflict in Ukraine served as a driving force, turning economic dependencies into tools for geopolitical struggle. The energy crisis caused by sanctions from the West against Russia highlighted the weaknesses of international supply chains. The subsequent rise in prices, especially in Europe, demonstrated a delicate dependence, with energy security turning into an issue of national importance. Moreover, the implementation of economic sanctions represented a significant shift in the use of financial systems (like SWIFT) and technological resources (such as semiconductors) as means of pressure. This economic division, where countries aim to lessen their vulnerability to geopolitical dangers, supports Heidenreich's viewpoint: infrastructures are no longer just technical aids, but arenas of power where competition among nations occurs. Competition is everywhere. The fast growth of artificial intelligence, fueled by major funding and speculation, resembles past financial bubbles. A potential collapse, similar to 2008, is possible since AI relies on big companies like NVIDIA, Google, and Meta, as well as regional imbalances between the U.S. and China. This digital economy changes the power structure, highlighting the importance of digital resources for national control.
But how is the theoretical framework balanced by nowadays structural evidence ?
The main issue is to determine if these crises indicate a Signal Crisis—a decrease in power of the current leader, which allows a new one to emerge—or a *Terminal Crisis*, which represents the failure of the system altogether. Arrighi's theoretical model provides a useful perspective to evaluate this conflict. Arrighi brings up an important question: do the ongoing crises indicate a *Signal Crisis*, reflecting the United States' gradual decline in favor of an emerging power, or a *Terminal Crisis*, representing an overall system failure? There are many indicators pointing to America's decline: staggering debt at 120% of GDP, deepening political divides, and diminishing global influence due to the rise of BRICS nations. China represents this shift in power, demonstrated by its Belt and Road Initiative, the introduction of its e-CNY currency, and its control over rare earth elements. Nevertheless, the United States still possesses significant strengths: the dollar remains dominant as 60% of global reserves, it has unmatched military power, and its soft power continues to be influential. A multipolar world involving the United States, China, and the European Union may come into being, which could help stabilize the current system instead of leading to its failure. Here, infrastructure—whether digital, financial, or physical—is crucial. It can either speed up the transition

(as China enforces its standards through the Belt and Road Initiative) or support the existing structure (evident in Beijing's reliance on Taiwanese semiconductor chips, influenced by America, thereby creating a shared system). Consequently, three possibilities arise: Chinese dominance (which signifies a *Terminal Crisis*), a balance of powers (representing a *Signal Crisis*), or systemic disorder (characterized by the breakdown of value chains and fragmentation of infrastructure).

In a nutshell, crises are not mere coincidences; they are pivotal events that expose the boundaries of dominance. Whether we witness a gradual decline, a complete collapse, or a move toward a multipolar world, infrastructure will serve as either the driving force or barrier, underlining that crises are essential indicators of an evolving global order. Across historical periods, crises emerge not as anomalies but as structural moments in which the alignment between coordination and abstraction breaks down, revealing the limits of hegemonic power.

"The prevalent beliefs are those of the elite"—Marx was not able to predict the rise of digital capitalism. However, history tends to repeat itself in alarming ways: in the past, banks in Genoa funded empires, Dutch exchanges facilitated international trade, and British telegraph lines linked a massive colonial network. Nowadays, it is underwater cables, monitoring algorithms, and online platforms that define our economic and political landscape. Those who wield control over these systems do more than just lead the economy; they influence global regulations, social customs, and even our shared perceptions. What if the next uprising didn't emerge from the streets, but from data hubs and systems. As we stand at this crossroads, the real question may not be *who* will dominate, but *how* these infrastructures will be governed. Will they serve as tools of emancipation, enabling a more equitable global order? Or will they become the new chains of dependency, locking nations and individuals into digital feudalism? The answer lies in the struggle over the infrastructures that shape our world—a struggle that has defined empires past, and will define the empires of the future. The question is therefore not only who controls these infrastructures, but whether their underlying logic—extraction, coordination, and dependency—can be transformed.The future of global order will therefore depend not only on which actors control these infrastructures, but on whether the fundamental logic that underpins them—coordination, abstraction, and dependency—can be reconfigured or transcended.

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